
MRP – New RTF Help System

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Introduction

The old system used HLP files which contain an RTF document and any icons/images.

Windows 10 onwards does not support this file format, so a new system needed to be found, preferably without losing the existing RTF data as this is the essence of the help system!

Any replacement system must also support or at least emulate the hyperlink function of the embedded RTF files.,

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How It Works

The new system uses RTF like the old, however it stores them in SQL Server in a custom table called:

Help

The schema for that table is:

Field Name	Type	Allow Nulls?	Primary Key?
HLP_Form	VarChar(255)	N	Y
HLP_HumanName	VarChar(255)	Y	N
HLP_Desc	Text	Y	N
Timestamp	timestamp	N	N

RTF data is stored there and an external program called from MRP with the help topic Id (HLP_Form), which is used to extract the RTF data from the SQL Server table and display it to the user.

An example would be help for the Employee Maintenance Form: HLP_Form equals frmEmpMaint

This value is passed to the external program to show the help data.

The HLP_HumanName field shows the name of the form as the users knows it e.g. Employee Maintenance, this also can be used when creating an RTF help file to make a “hyperlink” to another RTF help form.

E.g.:

Employee Maintenance

When the RTF help show program is run, it will see if the clicked text is: Color.Green, if it is it will search the Help SQL Server table using HLP_HumanName = “Employee Maintenance” then use the HLP_Form value to open the required RTF help File!

Note: If the form has tabs the tab name is appended onto the form name, for example in the Employee Maintenance Form there are four tabs. So there would be represented as: frmEmpMain_Security etc.

The green colour is RGB: 255,0,128,0

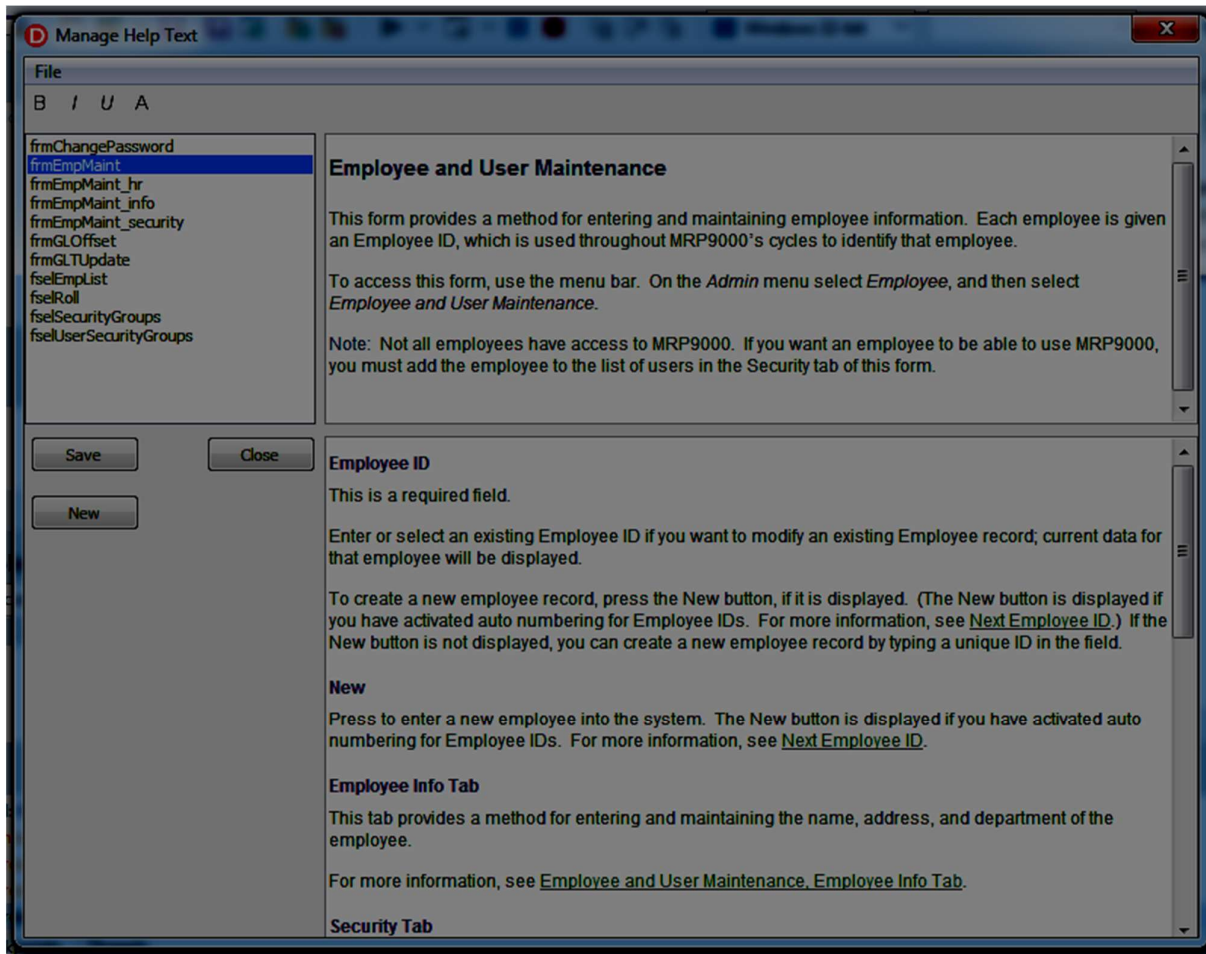
At this time there is no need for a control based help system, as the RTF data from the old system already explains what each relevant control does.

The Desc field is used to store the raw RTF data which includes formatting data, as this uses less storage space then saving an actual RTF file.

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Implementation

The extracted RTF files are loaded into Word then copy and pasted into the RTF help management form, so a new record can be created for the relevant form. E.g.:



This screen is representative of a sample program for maintaining the RTF data, design may change.

The MRP system has its own global code that handles the help request and displays the data by sending a command line to a program in the MRP directory.

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